

Root Cause

Designing talents across the country are rejuvenating traditional textiles with a modern twist, giving a new lease of life to age-old styles like bandhini

■ By Kimi Dangor

Call it knotted couture or twisted textile, the humble *bandhini* wowed audiences at the recently concluded Rosemount Australian Fashion Week. It took 300 skilled artisans to create the 50 unique garments showcased by NID alumni, designing duo Rahul Mishra and Samar Firdos. Beautifully draped, textured and knotted to fit, the traditional tie-dye technique of Bhuj, Kutch, made a stylish splash Down Under. From *bandhini* fabricated into the universal Little Black Dress to brilliant dashes of colour, the collection 'Shcen Unseen' gave this creative craft an international flavour and impetus. "We have not only contemporised the craft, but also preserved its value by giving it a new expression, with shorter lengths and new silhouettes," says designer Samar Firdos, fresh from his first international outing.

While Rahul & Firdos earlier impressed Mumbai audiences with their fall-winter line at the Lakme Fashion Week (LFW) featuring checks and solid *bhagalpuri* fabrics in houndstooth and tweed weaves, Dev r Nil used indigenously developed textiles from handloom weavers in Phulia, West Bengal, to give watchers at Rosemount a peep into Indian fashion. "We developed an interesting array of linen, viscose

linen, khadi cotton and a unique silk weave with *zari* for a futuristic-looking metallic fabric. Our creations always incorporate ethnic influences. And nothing can put the Indian touch across as beautifully as textiles. The idea is to customise differently," says Dev.

In similar local-going-global cases, designing talents across India are rejuvenating traditional textiles with a modern twist. Ecologically sensitive and traditionally sound, these young designers are keeping the country's vintage fabric breathing. "Using traditional textiles in

Shyamal & Bhumika



Ahmedabad's *Ashavali* sari has been given a new lease of life by this Ahmedabad-based duo.

"It was tough to get the weavers to weave the age-old designs."

